



RAILROAD ENGINEER

JOB DESCRIPTION

This skilled profession involves operating passenger or freight trains on local or national rail networks, stopping at stations or depots to collect and deliver passengers or cargo. The role requires acute concentration over long periods of time, and the ability to react quickly and calmly to unexpected situations. Engineers may specialize in a particular type of train, such as high-speed trains.



SALARY

Trainee railroad engineer ★★★★★

Experienced railroad engineer ★★★☆☆

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Large industry • Passenger transportation is the largest employer, followed by freight services • Competitive field, with many more applicants than jobs

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Trains and railroad equipment • Travel and transportation • Vehicle mechanics • Mathematics • Physics • Engineering • Geography



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS A good high-school education is usually sufficient, but some rail companies may ask for higher-level qualifications.



LIFESTYLE Railroad engineers work in shifts at any time of the day or night, during the working week, and on weekends and holidays.



LOCATION When working on long-distance routes, overnight stays may be required. Most engineers must live within an hour's travel from their home station.



THE REALITIES As they have to work alone for long periods, engineers must be self-motivated. Experienced staff are well-paid and receive free rail travel.

RELATED CAREERS

- ▶ **TRUCK DRIVER** *see pp. 224–225*
- ▶ **BUS DRIVER** Drives a bus on a particular route, picking up and dropping off passengers at marked bus stops. Bus drivers ensure the safety of passengers, sell tickets, and check bus passes.
- ▶ **COACH DRIVER** Drives a coach—either hired by a private group, or a public service that makes scheduled stops—to destinations such as airports, tourist attractions, or major cities. Coach drivers load and unload luggage, take fares, and check passenger lists.
- ▶ **RAIL ENGINEERING TECHNICIAN** Builds, maintains, and repairs train engines, cars, and wagons. Servicing a train's mechanical and electrical systems is an important part of the job.
- ▶ **TRAM DRIVER** Operates electrically powered trams on a fixed rail route in a town or city, taking on and dropping off passengers at stations.